Eukiah

By Lanford Wilson

Butch walks into the light. He is a young. powerful. charming man; everybody's best friend. He is also menacing. Nothing he says is introspective. Everything is for a purpose. During the indicated beats of silence he listens; for Eukiah to answer, for the sound of breathing, for the least indication of where Eukiah is. The play is a seduction. Voices have a slight echo in here.

BUTCH: Eukiah? *(Beat.)* Eukiah? *(Beat.)* Barry saw you run in here, so I know you're here. You're doin' it again, Eukiah, you're jumping to these weird conclusions you jump to just like some half-wit. You don't wanna be called a half-wit, you gotta stop actin' like a half-wit, don't ya? You're gettin' to where nobody can joke around you, ya know that? What kind of fun is a person like that to be around, huh? One you can't joke around? We talked about that before, remember? *(Beat.)*

INTRODUCTION

Eukiah, a young stable boy, earns his keep by caring for horses. Some people have an affinity for animals . . . After all, animals are safe. It loves you unconditionally and once you have been adopted by an animal, it would never hurt you. People, however, are much more complex. Eukiah, although viewed a backwards by most people, has learned this over time. Animals you can trust . . . but not people . . . not even family.

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BUTCH: What are you thinkin'? You thinkin' you heard Harry say something, you thought he meant it, didn't you? What did you think you heard? Huh? What'd you thing he meant? Eukiah? *(Beat.)* You're gonna have to talk to me, I can't talk to myself here. *(Beat.)* Have you ever known me to lie to you? Eukiah? Have you ever known that? *(Pause. He might walk*

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around some.) Okay. Boy, this old hangar sure seen better days, hasn't it? Just like everything else on this place, huh? Been pretty much a losing proposition since I've known it, though. Probably you too, hasn't it? Hell, I don't think they have the wherewithall anymore, give even one of those or barns a swab a paint. You think? Might paint 'em pink, whattaya think? Or candy stripes. Red and white. Peppermint. You'd like that. *(Beat.)* This'll remind you of old Mac's heyday, though, won't it? Private airplane hangar. Talk about echoes, this is an echo of the past, huh? or Mac had some winners, I guess, about twenty years ago. That must have been the life, huh? Private planes, keep 'em in your private hangar. You got your luncheons with the dukes and duchesses. Winner's Circle damn near every race. If they wasn't raised by 01' Mac or their sire or dam one wasn't raised by or Mac, I don't imagine anybody'd bother to bet on em, do you? Boy that's all gone, huh? Planes and limos and all, dukes and duchesses-good lookin' horses, though. Damn shame we can't enter 'em in a beauty contest somewhere. I know, you're attached to 'em, but I'll tell you they make damn expensive pets. What was you? Out by the paddock when Barry was talkin' to me? You think you overheard something, is that it? What do you think you heard? You want to talk about it? I know you'd rather talk to me than talk to Barry, huh? Eukiah? *(Pause.)* Is this where you come? When you run off all temperamental and sulking? Pretty nasty old place to play in. Echoes good though. Gotta keep awful quiet if you're trying to be secret like you always do in a place like this. Why do you do that? You got any idea? I'm serious, now. Run off

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like that. They're waitin' supper on you, I guess you know. You know how happy they're gonna be about it, too. *(Beat.)* Eukiah? What was it you think you heard, honey? What? Was it about the horses? Cause I thought I told you never trust anything anybody says if it's about horses.

EUKIAH: *(Still unseen.)* I heard what Barry said. You said you would. too.

BUTCH: *(Butch relaxes some. smiles.)* Where the dickens have you got to? There's so much echo in here I can't tell where you are. You back in those oil drums? You haven't crawled up in the rafters have you? Watch yourself. We don't want you getting' hurt. I don't think those horses would eat their oats at all, anybody gave 'em to 'em 'cept you. I think they'd flat out go on strike. Don't you figure?

EUKIAH: They wouldn't drink, you couldn't get 'em to.

BUTCH: Don't I know it. Pot-A-Gold, for sure. You're the only one to get him to do anything. I think he'd just dehydrate. He'd blow away, you wasn't leadin' him. We could lead him to water but we couldn't make him to drink, isn't that right? *(Beat.)* What are you hiding about? Nobody's gonna hurt you. Don't I always take up for you? You get the weirdest ideas. What do you think you heard Barry say?

EUKIAH: He's gonna bum the horses.

BUTCH: What? Oh, man. You are just crazy sometimes, these things you dream up. Who is? Barry? What would he wanna do something crazy like that for?

EUKIAH: I heard you talkin.'

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BUTCH: Can you answer me that? Why would he even dream of doin' something like that?

EUKIAH: For the insurance.

BUTCH: No, Eukiah. Just come on to supper, now, I got a date tonight, I can't mess around with you anymore. You really are a half-wit. I'm sorry, but if you think Barry'd do something like that, I'm sorry, that's just flat out half-witted thinkin'. It's not even funny. The way you talk, you yak all day to anybody around, no idea what you're saying half the time; anybody heard something like that there wouldn't be no work for me or you or anybody else around here, 'cause they'd just lock us all up.

EUKIAH: You said you would.

BUTCH: I would? I would what?

EUKIAH: You said it was about time somebody did somethin'.

BUTCH: Eukiah, come out here. I can see you over by that old buggy, my eyes got used to the dark. There ain't no sense in hiding anymore. *(Beat.)* Come on out, damn it, so we can go to supper. I'm not going to play with you anymore. Come on. Well, just answer me one thing. How's bumin' 'em up gonna be any better than splittin' a hoof or somethin' like that? Come on, crazy. The least little thing happens to make a horse not run, it's the same as if he had to be destroyed, you ought to know that. *(Eukiah is just visible now. He is maybe 16 years old. He is slow and soft; he has the mentality of an 8 year old.)*

EUKIAH: Yeah, but they already took Pot-A-Gold and Flashy and that gray one, the speckled one, off. They already sold 'em.

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BUTCH: Which one do you call Flashy, you mean Go Carmen? The filly? And Old Ironside? Why would they do that?

EUKIAH: Cause they're the best ones. Then they put three no good horses in their stalls, so nobody would know. And they're gonna burn 'em and nobody would know. And they're gonna burn 'em and nobody can tell they ain't the horses they're supposed to be, Butchy.

BUTCH: Nobody could run Pot-A-Gold somewhere else, Euky. You know those numbers they tattoo in his mouth? That's gonna identify him no matter where he goes, anybody'll know that's Pot-A-Gold.

EUKIAH: Some other country. They wouldn't care.

BUTCH: Anywhere on earth.

EUKIAH: They got some plan where it'll work, 'cause I heard 'em.

BUTCH: I don't know what you think you heard, but you're really acting half-witted here.

EUKIAH: Don't call me

BUTCH: Well, I'm sorry, but what would you call it? A person can't bum down a bam full of horses, Euky. What a horrible thing to think. No wonder you get scared, you scare yourself thinking things like that. Those horses are valued, hell I don't even know, millions of dollars probably. Insurance inspectors come around, they take a place apart. You tell me, how would somebody get away with a trick like that?

EUKIAH: What was you talkin' about then?

BUTCH: I don't even know. Where it was you heard what you thought you heard. You're too fast for me. You'll just have to go in to supper and ask Mac what Harry was talking about, won't you? Would that make you

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feel better? Instead of jumpin' to your weird conclusions. Now, can you get that out of your head? Huh? So we can go eat and I can take a bath and go on my date? Is that all right with you? Then I'll come back and tell you all about it. Got a date with Mary, you'd like to hear about that, wouldn't you? *(Eukiah begins to grin.)* Yes? That's okay with you, is it?,

EUKIAH: I guess. *(He moves into the light, closer to Butch.)*

BUTCH: You guess. You're just going to have to trust me, Eukiah, no body needs money that bad. Not even on this place. I don't even think nobody could get away tryin' to pull something like that. *(He puts his arm around Eukiah's neck and they start to move off, but Butch has Eukiah in a head lock. He speaks with the strain of exertion.)* Not unless there was some half-wit on the place that got his neck broke being kicked in the head and got burned up in the fire. *(Eukiah goes to his knees. Butch bears down on his neck; it breaks with a dull snap. He lets Eukiah slump to the floor. Butch is breathing hard, standing over Eukiah's body.)* I thought I told you. Never trust anything anybody says if it's about horses.

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